

Chapter 80_2 - Destiny

The autumn colors within Tranquil Mountain Palace seemed not to have penetrated thoroughly. Along the palace paths, colorful flowers still swayed in the sunlight, and fallen leaves had already been swept clean by immortal attendants, leaving the stone-paved roads smooth and tidy.

Chu Qingqiu sat in the lakeside pavilion at the end of the covered bridge, her black hair hanging down both sides as she played the qin¹. The melodious sound of the seven-stringed ancient qin leaped from the pavilion and drifted away with the wind.

Qiuyi, dressed in purple robes, appeared from mid-air and landed in the pavilion, bowing her head: "Master, I have already secretly spread the news of your serious illness as instructed."

"Moreover, I have also secretly delivered confidential letters to the medical immortals in our sect, asking them to come for consultation tonight."

As she spoke, she looked up and hesitated for a moment before saying: "Master, by doing this, are you waiting for that demon clan person to make their move? Aren't you afraid he..."

"I'm not waiting for him to act, but forcing him to act. His delay in moving must be due to some concerns - perhaps he lacks full confidence, or fears my reputation. I need him to become careless and be forced to expose his identity before fully planning, falling into my formation on his own. Striking after the enemy moves first will give us better odds of victory."

"Then how do you know he'll take the bait?"

"He'll never find a better opportunity than now to strike. I'm severely injured and haven't recovered, the other five sects are far away in the Eastern Wilderness. If he acts, no one can stop him."

"Plus, I spread false news saying the Eastern Wilderness matter is about to end and the sect leaders and elders of various sects will soon return. If he doesn't want to miss this opportunity, he naturally won't be able to contain himself," Chu Qingqiu said while continuing her hand movements, the qin music still carrying long, lingering notes.

"Worthy of Master," Qiuyi said, though her eyes were full of worry. "But what if that demon clan member doesn't come for Master and instead targets Ning Fuyi?"

Chu Qingqiu struck a wrong note, then continued: "I've already cast a spell on her. If there's any unusual activity around her, I can appear instantly."

"So whether that demon clan member comes for me or Ning Fuyi, there's no real difference."

As the master and disciple were talking, two figures crossed the barrier and appeared on the covered bridge, their robes fluttering gracefully, black hair like clouds.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips tensed for an instant, and the originally flowing qin music seemed like cutting water with a blade, stopping abruptly with a buzzing sound.

She had broken a qin string.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips curled for a moment, then she looked up to see the woman walking toward her with a smile, her face rosy, clearly in an excellent mood.

"Chu Qingqiu!" Ning Fuyi smiled as she crossed the bridge to her side, her cheeks flushed, radiating a brightness that hadn't appeared for a long time.

Qiuyi was about to say something when Jiuying beside her grabbed her with a claw, also pulling away Jiang Li who had come running at the sound, holding one with each hand as she walked toward the other end of the winding corridor.

"Come, come, come! I think this covered bridge is quite beautiful. Come with me to take a look," she said, swaying her waist.

Chu Qingqiu took one look and seemed to have her eyes burned. She didn't dare look up again, pretending to casually reach out to touch the qin string, trying to restore it, but failed.

"What is it," she said.

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment. Her originally bright smile faded slightly, and her words turned at the last moment: "Oh, I have something to discuss with you."

She took out that Bone Enchantress flower from her sleeve and placed it on Chu Qingqiu's qin strings: "This was discovered by Jiuying, hidden among ordinary Red Spider Lilies. I think this must be what that demon clan is planning to do with these. I was afraid you hadn't noticed, so I came to tell you."

Chu Qingqiu glanced at the flower and waved her sleeve to brush it away: "Thank you, but I already knew."

Ning Fuyi watched the flower disappear, her red lips slightly parted. The surging sea in her heart seemed to be pressed back down, her fingertips couldn't help but curl: "I heard about the message you released. You've arranged everything, waiting for that person to show themselves."

"I can help you deal with that demon clan together.."

"No need. The Waning Moon Formation² has been properly arranged. You just need to stay in your room," Chu Qingqiu used her cold tone to interrupt Ning Fuyi's words, but still didn't look at her.

"Chu Qingqiu." Ning Fuyi's voice also grew cold. "That day you promised me we would deal with the demon clan together."

"I haven't broken my promise. You staying put is serving as bait to lure that demon clan," Chu Qingqiu said. This time she finally finished repairing the ancient qin.

"You can't deceive me. That demon clearly wants to kill both you and me together. How do you know he'll come for me? What you're doing is clearly trying to keep me out of it, leaving you alone to deal with the demon clan." Ning Fuyi stepped closer two paces, her hands trembling beneath her beautiful dress.

"So what if it is? With your level of cultivation, how could you deal with it? There are so many people in Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate whose cultivation surpasses yours. I could seek help from anyone - why must I seek you?" Chu Qingqiu said indifferently.

Her voice was merciless, as merciless as in her previous life, cold without a trace of warmth.

Ning Fuyi felt the sea in her heart suddenly turn cold. She tried to speak several times but couldn't, finally curving her lips instead: "So in your eyes now, I'm still no different from any other disciple in this sect?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't speak, but also never looked at her, as if acquiescing.

The hostility that hadn't surfaced in Ning Fuyi's heart for a long time began to emerge again, her features becoming increasingly profound. She simply stood in front of her, forcibly blocking her line of sight.

"Then what about what we did yesterday? What does that count as? You condescending to graciously save my life, or you being bored and amusing yourself by toying with me?"

Chu Qingqiu bit her tongue until it hurt, looking up in surprise, then quickly forcing herself to lower her gaze, her long eyelashes covering her vision.

"I..."

"You want to say it wasn't you who did it again." Ning Fuyi was so angry she could crush her silver teeth, laughing in extreme anger. "You've hidden so many things from me, and now you want to hide even this!"

As she spoke, she suddenly reached out and grasped Chu Qingqiu's arm, forcibly turning her wrist to reveal the shallow red mark on it.

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth in rebuke, struggling hard, but Ning Fuyi suddenly let go. Chu Qingqiu rose in distress, and in her panic knocked the qin to the ground. The jarring sound of tangled strings pierced through ears and throat, making one's heart uncomfortable.

Ning Fuyi's slender hand still hung in mid-air. She clearly felt like crying, but her eyes were dry, and the corners of her lips were still curved upward.

"This was left by me using a secret technique that day. Only I can remove it," she said softly, then lowered her hand, and that faint red mark disappeared.

"How foolish of me to think so highly of myself. How foolish of me to feel that in the thousand years I've lived, I was happy for the first time when I woke up today. It turns out I was still wrong." Ning Fuyi lowered the corners of her mouth, her tone even more indifferent than Chu Qingqiu's.

"It turns out you never changed, Chu Qingqiu. You have no heart."

Though it was still bright and sunny weather, the two people standing face to face were competing to see who could be colder. Chu Qingqiu only felt her heart aching sourly, standing there woodenly.

"Stop eavesdropping, come out," Ning Fuyi said indifferently. Three figures immediately appeared behind her, standing in a row with their heads lowered.

"Ning, Ning Fuyi, don't go too far. Master is clearly trying to save you," Qiuyi hesitated for a long time before deciding to speak up for her master.

"Enough. Hurting someone's body is nothing compared to chilling their heart. If I had known, I wouldn't have said those words. It would have been better than letting this girl's devoted heart feed the three-foot-deep cold river³."

"Let's go, let's go, let's go back..." Jiuying really couldn't bear to watch anymore. She stepped forward and took Ning Fuyi's arm. With a flash of red light, the two disappeared outside the barrier.

"Master..." Qiuyi wanted to step forward to comfort Chu Qingqiu, but Chu Qingqiu said: "It's alright, you may go."

Seeing that Qiuyi was unwilling to leave, she emphasized her tone: "Go."

Only then did the person leave. She closed her eyes tightly, her legs that had already gone weak finally couldn't support her, and she swayed as she fell. Jiang Li quickly threw out a silk cloth to support her as she sat down.

Jiang Li was also at a loss, hiding the redness around her eyes: "Divine Venerable, why do you torment yourself like this, tormenting both her and yourself? Originally I thought the young sect leader might have no feelings for you, but seeing this now, she has long been moved to love, even without knowing it herself."

"Even if your lifespan is coming to an end, even if you must eliminate that demon clan and use your body as the formation's eye, what harm would there be in just telling her that you care about her?"

"And then what? Watch her be pierced through the heart by a sword again because of me, falling to the Yellow Springs⁴?" Chu Qingqiu shook her head, letting her disheveled hair brush across her face. "I don't want that. I want her to live, even if she hates me for a lifetime."

Jiang Li listened in bewilderment, completely confused. Looking at the woman sitting dejectedly on the stone bench, she seemed to have changed her immortal form in a trance, her clear lake-like peach blossom eyes revealing a hint of madness.

"Jiang Li, I never believed in destiny, yet I still made two wishes to heaven," Chu Qingqiu gazed at the autumn colors stretching to the horizon. "Once, that whatever she seeks shall be my wish as well."

"And another time, that she must never, ever fall in love with me in the future."

Footnotes:

¹ **Qin (琴)** - A traditional Chinese seven-stringed musical instrument, often associated with scholarly pursuits and refinement

² **Waning Moon Formation (残月阵)** - A specific type of battle formation, likely named for its crescent or incomplete circular shape

³ **Three-foot-deep cold river (三尺寒川)** - A poetic expression referring to something cold and unforgiving, often used metaphorically for someone who is heartless or unresponsive to love

⁴ **Yellow Springs (黄泉)** - In Chinese mythology, the underworld or realm of the dead